



## MINDFUL DIABETES FREE GUIDES

Simple, practical guidance for metabolic and brain health.

# Fats Without Fear

A Plain-English Guide to Dietary Fats, Heart Health, and Brain Health

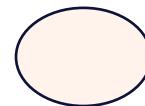
FREE GUIDE



fish



nuts



oil



avocado

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WELCOME

# Fat is not something to fear

Fat is an essential nutrient and food would be dull without it. The useful question is not whether fat is allowed, but which fat sources show up most often and what they replace.



## Nuts/seeds

unsaturated fat plus texture



## Fish

protein and omega-3 sources



## Avocado

unsaturated fat and fiber



## Oils

use amounts that fit

- You will learn the main fat types, how to read labels, and how to try practical swaps.
- Ask for individualized advice if you have pancreatitis, gallbladder disease, high triglycerides, kidney disease, or a prescribed diet.



## WHAT FAT DOES

# What dietary fat does in the body

Fat helps build cell membranes, carries flavor, supports fullness, and helps the body absorb vitamins A, D, E, and K.

- Food source matters more than one isolated number.
- Nuts, oils, fish, dairy, meats, and fried foods are not nutritionally identical.



### Saturated

common in butter, cheese, fatty meats, tropical oils



### Monounsaturated

olive oil, avocado, nuts



### Polyunsaturated

seeds, fish, soybean and sunflower oils



### Trans fat

avoid partially hydrogenated oils



**FAT TYPES**

# Saturated, unsaturated, and trans fats

Saturated, monounsaturated, polyunsaturated, and trans fats behave differently. The American Heart Association recommends limiting saturated fat and avoiding trans fat, while choosing unsaturated fats in place of saturated fat when possible. [6]



## Saturated

common in butter, cheese, fatty meats, tropical oils



## Monounsaturated

olive oil, avocado, nuts



## Polyunsaturated

seeds, fish, soybean and sunflower oils



## Trans fat

avoid partially hydrogenated oils

- Saturated fats are common in butter, cheese, fatty meats, and tropical oils.
- Unsaturated fats are common in non-tropical liquid oils, nuts, seeds, avocado, and fish.



REPLACEMENT

# Why replacement matters

Notice the saturated-fat source

Choose what will replace it

Prefer unsaturated fat, beans, vegetables, fruit, or whole grains

Keep flavor and satisfaction

Repeat the swap if it works

A lower-saturated-fat pattern works best when saturated fat is replaced by unsaturated fat sources, vegetables, beans, fruit, and whole grains, not simply by refined starches or added sugar. [6]

- Swap, do not just subtract.
- Look at the overall eating pattern.



**BLOOD FATS**

# LDL, HDL, and triglycerides

LDL cholesterol is often called 'bad' cholesterol because higher levels can contribute to plaque in arteries. HDL and triglycerides are also part of cardiovascular risk, but no single number tells the whole story.



## LDL

one important risk marker



## HDL

part of the larger picture



## Triglycerides

affected by many factors

- Ask what your personal numbers mean.
- Do not start supplements for cholesterol or triglycerides without guidance.



COOKING OILS

# Cooking oils

| Oil/source        | Common use       | Context                |
|-------------------|------------------|------------------------|
| Olive             | saute, dressings | unsaturated fat source |
| Canola            | baking, saute    | neutral flavor         |
| Soybean/sunflower | general cooking  | compare labels         |
| Coconut/palm      | specific recipes | higher saturated fat   |

Non-tropical liquid plant oils such as olive, canola, soybean, sunflower, avocado, corn, and peanut oils are generally useful options. Coconut and palm oils are higher in saturated fat and should not be treated as miracle foods. [7]

- Choose an oil that fits the recipe and budget.
- Use measured amounts when portions are a concern.



## NUTS AND AVOCADO

# Nuts, seeds, and avocado

These foods can add unsaturated fats, fiber, minerals, texture, and satisfaction. They are calorie-dense, which is a neutral fact, not a moral warning.

- Try peanuts, walnuts, sunflower seeds, pumpkin seeds, chia, flax, or avocado.
- Buy small bags or store-brand options if cost matters.



### Nuts/seeds

unsaturated fat plus texture



### Fish

protein and omega-3 sources



### Avocado

unsaturated fat and fiber



### Oils

use amounts that fit





FISH

# Fish and omega-3 fats



## Salmon

fresh, frozen, or  
canned



## Sardines

budget-friendly for  
some



## Tuna

check mercury  
guidance when  
relevant



## Supplements

ask before starting

Fish can be a useful protein source and fatty fish provides omega-3 fats. Eating fish is different from assuming everyone needs an omega-3 supplement.

- Canned salmon, sardines, or tuna may be budget options.
- Pregnancy, allergies, mercury concerns, and medications require individualized advice.

### Supplement caution

Do not treat omega-3 supplements as universally needed. Ask your clinician if supplements are safe for you.



**DAIRY FATS**

# Butter, cheese, cream, and full-fat dairy

Butter, cream, cheese, and many full-fat dairy foods can be higher in saturated fat. You do not have to ban them, but it helps to notice frequency and portion.

## More saturated fat

- Butter as default spread
- Cream-heavy sauces
- Large cheese portions

## Flexible swaps

- Olive oil when it fits
- Plain yogurt
- Smaller amount of strong cheese

- Use strong flavors in smaller amounts.
- Try yogurt, lower-fat dairy, or plant options when they fit your needs.



TROPICAL OILS

# Coconut and palm oils

Natural does not automatically mean heart-supportive. Coconut and palm oils are plant-based but still high in saturated fat. [7]

## Be careful with claims

- Coconut oil is high in saturated fat
- Palm oil is also saturated-fat rich

## Use context

- Use less often for LDL concerns
- Choose non-tropical oils more often

- Use them less often if LDL cholesterol is a concern.
- Avoid miracle-food claims.



**FRIED FOODS**

# Fried and ultra-processed foods

Fried foods and many packaged snacks can combine refined starch, sodium, saturated fat, and large portions. The issue is the pattern, not a single food.

## Frequent pattern

- Fried entree plus fries
- Sugary drink
- Few vegetables

## Supportive pattern

- Share or choose smaller portion
- Add vegetables
- Choose lower-sugar drink

- Choose less often, share a portion, or pair with vegetables.
- Read labels on packaged foods.



**LABEL READING**

# Reading the Nutrition Facts label

| Label area         | Why it matters            | Helpful check           |
|--------------------|---------------------------|-------------------------|
| Serving size       | Numbers are based on this | Compare to your portion |
| Total carbohydrate | Glucose planning          | Check grams             |
| Added sugar        | Food quality clue         | Lower is often easier   |
| Saturated fat      | Heart-health context      | Compare similar foods   |
| Sodium             | Blood pressure context    | 5% low, 20% high        |

The label lists total fat, saturated fat, trans fat, serving size, and Percent Daily Value. The FDA notes that 5% DV or less is low and 20% DV or more is high for a nutrient. [3]

- Start with serving size.
- Compare saturated fat across similar foods.



**BREAKFAST SWAPS**

# Breakfast swaps

A swap should still taste like breakfast. Keep one familiar food and change the fat source or add fiber.

## Current choice

- Pastry plus sweet coffee
- Butter-heavy toast

## Possible swap

- Yogurt, berries, nuts
- Avocado or nut butter toast

- Avocado on toast instead of butter sometimes.
- Plain yogurt with nuts instead of sweetened pastry.
- Eggs with vegetables instead of a fried-meat side.



MEAL SWAPS

# Lunch and dinner swaps

Try beans, fish, tofu, or lean poultry more often. Use olive oil vinaigrette instead of creamy dressing sometimes.

## Current choice

- Creamy dressing
- Meat-centered plate
- Fried side

## Possible swap

- Vinaigrette
- Beans, fish, tofu, poultry
- Vegetable side

- Swap frequency, not identity.
- Make the meal satisfying enough to repeat.



SNACK SWAPS

# Snack swaps

For crunch, try nuts, roasted chickpeas, popcorn, vegetables with hummus, or whole-grain crackers with tuna.

## Quick but less lasting

- Chips alone
- Sweet pastry
- Sugary drink

## More staying power

- Nuts and fruit
- Hummus and vegetables
- Yogurt and berries

- For sweet snacks, pair fruit with yogurt, nuts, or nut butter.
- Planned snacks can prevent grazing for some people.





**BUDGET**

# Budget-friendly fats

Healthy fat choices do not have to be expensive. Peanuts, sunflower seeds, canola oil, canned fish, eggs, and store-brand nut butters can all fit.



## Peanuts

often lower cost



## Sunflower seeds

crunch and fat



## Canola oil

neutral cooking option



## Canned fish

shelf-stable protein

- Buy what you will actually use.
- Avoid letting premium wellness foods define health.



MYTHS

# Myths and frequently asked questions

Fat-free does not always mean healthier, keto does not automatically mean heart-supportive, and coconut oil is not a cure-all.



## Fat-free

not always healthier



## Keto

not automatically heart-supportive



## Coconut oil

not a miracle food



## Supplements

not universal

- Look past front-package claims.
- Use your lab numbers and clinician guidance.



PLANNER

# Personal fat-swap planner

Choose one meal where a fat swap feels realistic. Write the current choice, one possible replacement, cost, taste, and whether you would repeat it.

| Meal | Current choice | Possible swap | Cost | Taste | Repeat? | Notes |
|------|----------------|---------------|------|-------|---------|-------|
|      |                |               |      |       |         |       |
|      |                |               |      |       |         |       |
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|      |                |               |      |       |         |       |
|      |                |               |      |       |         |       |
|      |                |               |      |       |         |       |



**NEXT STEPS**

# Heart and brain health summary

Dietary fat choices matter most as part of a larger pattern that also includes vegetables, fiber-rich foods, movement, sleep, blood pressure, cholesterol, glucose care, and clinical guidance.

- Explore the Mindful Plate guide.
- Ask your clinician what your cholesterol numbers mean.
- Share the guide with someone who feels confused by fat advice.

Explore the Guide

Visit Health Tools

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## Medical disclaimer

This guide is general education, not medical advice. Individual needs vary. Do not change medication, insulin, or glucose targets based on this guide.



## REFERENCES AND SAFETY

# References and medical disclaimer

### Medical disclaimer

This guide is for general education only. It is not medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment. Individual needs vary. Do not change medication, insulin, or glucose targets based on this guide. Seek appropriate medical attention for severe low blood sugar, severe high blood sugar, sudden confusion, chest pain, trouble breathing, fainting, seizures, or other urgent symptoms.

## References

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